Digital Analysis of Domenico Gerosolimitano's Hebrew Translation of the New Testament: A 17th Century Cultural Bridge

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Introduction

Domenico Gerosolimitano (born Samuel Vivas, c. 1555) represents a fascinating figure in Jewish-Christian relations during the 16th-17th centuries. Born into a Jewish family in Jerusalem, he received his early education in the Galilee region, primarily in Safed, where he studied Talmud and Kabbalah and served as a rabbi and religious judge (dayan). His intellectual pursuits extended beyond religious studies to medicine, leading to his appointment as the personal physician to Ottoman Sultan Murad III, a prestigious position he held for 16 years.

On August 6, 1593, at the age of 38, he converted to Christianity and adopted the name Domenico Gerosolimitano. Following his conversion, like many converts of his time, he became one of the most prominent and active censors of Hebrew books in service of the Catholic Church, a role he maintained until 1621. According to his own testimony, he censored over 20,000 copies of printed books and Hebrew manuscripts. Beyond his censorship duties, Domenico authored several Hebrew works aimed at persuading Jews to embrace Christianity. Among his significant contributions was his Hebrew translation of the New Testament, preserved in three manuscripts at the Vatican Library (Neofiti 32-34, 1616-1617) (Prebor, 2007; 2010/2011).

Historical Context

The New Testament entered Jewish intellectual discourse through polemical texts, apologetic writings, and missionary efforts. Medieval Jewish authors, such as Jacob ben Reuben and Shem Tov Ibn Shaprut, translated portions of the New Testament for anti-Christian arguments. In contrast, 16th-century Christian Hebraists like Sebastian Münster and Jean du Tillet produced translations aimed at promoting Christianity among Jews. Domenico's work stands out as a personal and theological effort to make the New Testament accessible to Hebrew speakers (Howard, 1987; Rosenthal, 1962; Shuali, 2016, 2023).

Research Questions

This study employs digital humanities methodologies to address several key questions:

1. What were Domenico's primary source texts, and how did he navigate between different linguistic traditions (Syriac/Aramaic, Greek, Latin, and Arabic)?
2. How does his translation methodology reflect his unique position as a Jewish convert to Christianity?
3. What can computational analysis reveal about his translation choices and their theological implications?

Methodology and Digital Tools

The project leverages DICTA's suite of digital tools for Hebrew textual analysis (https://dicta.org.il/):

- Version comparison tools for identifying textual variants and patterns
- Reference detection system for locating biblical and rabbinic citations
- Morphological analysis tools for examining Hebrew language usage
- Search and concordance tools for tracking terminology across texts

These tools enable:

- Systematic comparison of Domenico's translation choices with other Hebrew New Testament translations
- Identification of biblical and rabbinic terminology in the translation
- Analysis of morphological patterns and linguistic choices
- Mapping of intertextual connections to Jewish sources

Preliminary Findings

Initial examination of Domenico's translation already reveals interesting findings regarding his source texts. Although in his introduction Domenico explicitly states that he translated from multiple languages (Syriac/Aramaic, Greek, Latin, and Arabic), preliminary comparison shows that his translation appears to follow primarily the Peshitta (Syriac) version.

Figure 1 presents a parallel alignment table comparing five Hebrew translations of Matthew Chapter 2 :1-7: Domenico's translation, the Peshitta, Ibn Shaprut's version, Münster's translation, and du Tillet's text. This comparative layout demonstrates how each translator rendered specific terms and phrases and highlights the apparent relationship between Domenico's translation and the Peshitta.

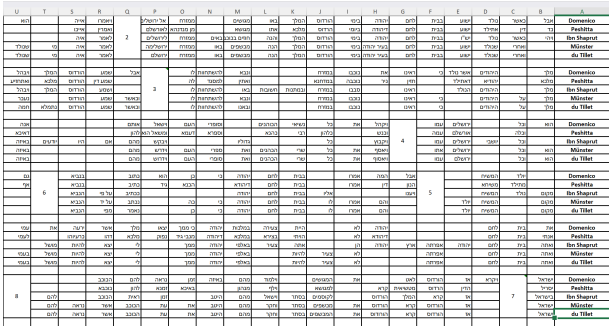

Figure 1: A Comparative Analysis of Matthew Chapter 2:1-7: Parallel Study of Five Translations

The project aims to examine how Domenico integrated rabbinic Hebrew terminology within Christian theological contexts. By applying computational analysis, we hope to uncover his translation strategies, particularly investigating whether and how he utilized familiar Jewish religious terminology to make the text more accessible to Jewish readers while maintaining Christian theological meanings.

Significance and Innovation

This project demonstrates how digital humanities methodologies can:

- Reveal previously undetected patterns in historical translation practices
- Provide quantitative evidence for source text relationships
- Offer new insights into early modern Jewish-Christian intellectual exchange
- Create accessible digital resources for further scholarly investigation

The poster will present visualizations of textual relationships and translation patterns, demonstrating how DICTA's digital tools reveal Domenico's translation strategies and his use of biblical and rabbinic terminology. Examples will include comparative tables showing parallel translations, charts of terminology usage patterns, and highlighted instances of rabbinic and biblical references.

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